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MASTER THESIS

Learning to Couple:
Acute Effects of Rhythmic Stick Manipulation on Fractal Heart Rate Dynamics

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Abstract

[todo: write after results; this is a placeholder of the right length and shape]

The beat-to-beat fluctuations of the healthy heart are correlated across time scales, and the short-term scaling exponent of detrended fluctuation analysis (DFA α_1) summarises this organisation in a single number that remains informative during physical activity. Movement practices built around handling an object are often described by practitioners as absorbing and restorative, but whether they leave a measurable acute trace in autonomic regulation has not been tested.

The present study recorded RR intervals with a Polar H10 chest strap while participants stood still holding the stick and while they performed two rhythmic stick-manipulation movements, isolations and spins, each for two minutes. α_1 was estimated per trial with an open analysis pipeline and compared between rest and movement, between the two movements, and between participants of differing expertise, with mean heart rate as a covariate to separate effects of skill from effects of physical load.

[todo: results in two to three sentences: direction of the shift, whether it survives the heart-rate adjustment, movement and expertise effects]

[todo: one to two sentences of interpretation and what follows for the stick as a research tool]

Keywords: heart rate variability, detrended fluctuation analysis, DFA alpha1, fractal physiology, object manipulation, motor skill, expertise, flow, Polar H10

Acknowledgements and Author's Contributions

This master's thesis is supervised by [confirm: first and second supervisor: Prof. Dr. Felix Blankenburg (Freie Universität Berlin) and Prof. Dr. Timo T. Schmidt (Medical School Berlin)]. [todo: ethics: approval by the Ethics Committee of the Department of Education and Psychology, Freie Universität Berlin (number), or the data-collection arrangement agreed with the supervisors]

The research question, the experimental design and the recording protocol were developed by the author. The isolation sticks were provided by seks.design. The capture software that receives RR intervals from the streaming application, and the analysis pipeline for artifact correction, HRV metrics and DFA α_1, were written by the author for this study. Data were collected by the author.

All analyses were conducted in Python [todo: version] with NumPy, SciPy and statsmodels [todo: versions]. The code is available at `https://github.com/daftpants10/seks`.

[todo: generative AI tools used (name, maker, version, purpose), in line with the declaration]

[todo: thanks]

Contents

1 Introduction and Experimental Objective **1**

2 Background **3**
2.1 Cardiac Autonomic Control and Heart Rate Variability . . . 3
2.2 Fractal Physiology and Detrended Fluctuation Analysis . . . 4
2.3 Acute Changes in DFA α_1 . . . 6
2.4 Rhythmic Movement, Sound and Cardiorespiratory Coupling . . . 7
2.5 Skill, Expertise and Flow . . . 9
2.6 Measuring RR Intervals Outside the Laboratory . . . 10
2.7 Research Gap . . . 11
2.8 Hypotheses . . . 12

3 Methods **12**
3.1 Participants . . . 12
3.2 The Stick and the Movements . . . 13
3.3 Experimental Paradigm . . . 14
3.4 Technical Setup . . . 15
3.5 Real-time Metrics . . . 16
3.6 Questionnaires . . . 16

4 Offline Data Analysis **16**
4.1 Preprocessing . . . 16
4.2 Heart Rate and Amplitude Indices . . . 17
4.3 DFA α_1 . . . 17
4.4 Pilot Checks . . . 18
4.5 Statistics . . . 18

5 Results **19**
5.1 Data Quality and Sample . . . 19
5.2 Descriptive Statistics . . . 19
5.3 Hypothesis 1: Does Stick Manipulation Shift α_1? . . . 19
5.4 Hypothesis 2: Does the Shift Exceed What Heart Rate Explains? . . . 19
5.5 Hypothesis 3: Does the Shift Depend on Expertise? . . . 19
5.6 Exploratory Analyses . . . 19

6 Discussion **20**
6.1 Direction of the Shift . . . 20
6.2 Skill or Load? . . . 21
6.3 Expertise . . . 21
6.4 The Stick as a Research Tool . . . 22
6.5 Implications: Towards a Somatic Interface . . . 22
6.6 Limitations and Future Research . . . 23

7 Conclusion **23**

8 Appendix **28**
8.1 Abbreviations 28
8.2 Trial File Format 28
8.3 Pre-session Questionnaire 29
8.4 Supplementary Tables 29

1 Introduction and Experimental Objective

Even at rest, the interval between two consecutive heartbeats changes from one beat to the next. In healthy people these changes are correlated across time scales, so that the pattern of fluctuation over a few beats resembles the pattern over minutes and hours [19, 35]. This fractal organisation is thought to reflect the interplay of many regulatory loops acting on the sinoatrial node at once, and it degrades in characteristic ways with disease and ageing [19, 33]. The beat-to-beat timing of the heart therefore offers a continuous, non-invasive readout of how the nervous system is regulating the body.

Heart rate variability is the measure of choice here for practical and theoretical reasons. It is recorded beat by beat with a chest strap that tolerates movement. It can therefore follow a person through a movement practice that would be impossible inside a scanner or under an EEG cap. It reflects the output of a central autonomic network whose cortical nodes overlap with those of attention and self-regulation [3, 45], which makes it a bodily trace of central regulation. And it is already measured by consumer wearables, so any reliable relation between a practice and HRV can be carried out of the laboratory into everyday use.

Most research on heart rate variability (HRV) quantifies how much the heartbeat varies, using indices such as the root mean square of successive differences (RMSSD). These amplitude indices are informative at rest but collapse towards a floor as soon as physical activity rises, losing resolution exactly where a movement task places the participant [21]. The short-term scaling exponent of detrended fluctuation analysis (DFA α_1) quantifies how this variation is organised over windows of 4 to 16 beats. α_1 sits near 1.0 in rested, healthy adults, falls towards 0.75 around the first ventilatory threshold and towards 0.5 at high exercise intensity [36, 37]. Because it keeps a dynamic range under load and can be estimated from about two minutes of data [11, 36], it is a candidate marker for short bouts of physically light but attentionally demanding movement.

One such class of movement is skilled object manipulation, such as juggling, poi, staff and stick work, which are widely practised and which practitioners describe as absorbing, calming and restorative, often in the vocabulary of flow [13]. In cognitive neuroscience, object manipulation already serves as a model of skill learning, since learning to juggle changes grey and white matter within weeks to months [17, 41]. The state of the body during manipulation itself has received far less attention.

These practices belong to a community usually called the *flow arts*. Here, props such as poi, staffs, hoops and sticks are practised as a movement discipline, a performance art and, for many, a contemplative practice. The present work grows out of seks.design, an experience-design practice that combines flow-arts movement with *somatic journaling*, the structured recording of bodily sensations alongside reports of mental state. Its guiding idea, called here *somatic interfacing*, is that signals from the body can serve as an interface for tracking, and eventually shaping, mental states. The longer-term aim is a model of conscious experience grounded in embodiment, in which movement, bodily signals and reported experience are mapped onto one another [confirm: wording of the seks.design description]. This thesis takes one step in that direction by asking whether a specific flow-arts movement leaves a measurable trace in cardiac regulation. If a practice reliably induces a distinct state of engagement, that state should leave a trace in autonomic regulation during the practice itself, and α_1 offers a way to look for it.

A second motivation comes from the study of rhythmic coordination. During walking, running and cycling, breathing tends to lock into stable frequency ratios with the movement cycle. An external rhythm such as a metronome can stabilise this locomotor–respiratory coupling and lower its energetic cost [2, 24]. Music and rhythmic sound, in turn, modulate arousal and can entrain cardiovascular rhythms [4, 47]. A rhythmic upper-limb movement therefore offers a plausible route from movement to breathing to the heart, and one in which mechanical coupling plays a smaller role than in locomotion. Whether such coordination behaves like a skill, weak in novices and stable in experts, is the broader question that gives this thesis its title.

The present study uses an isolation stick, a prop of about 50 cm with a weight at each end that produces a rhythmic figure-eight motion. Isolation sticks were created more than 20 years ago by the French artist and manipulation specialist Alexandre "Pich" of Le Cirque Graphique. His design drew on Michael Moschen's work on rhythm and motion in object manipulation [todo: source for the history of the isolation stick]. Participants performed two families of movement with it. *Isolations* keep one point of the stick fixed in space while the hand moves around it; they are slow, precise and visually guided. *Spins* rotate the stick continuously around the hand; they are faster and more rhythmic. I recorded RR intervals with a Polar H10 chest strap and streamed them to a laptop. An open pipeline then computed α_1, heart rate and amplitude indices of HRV for each two-minute trial. The control was a two-minute standing baseline in which participants held the stick still.

The experimental objective was to establish whether two minutes of stick manipulation shift α_1 relative to standing still with the stick, and in which direction. Because α_1 falls with exercise intensity, a shift could simply reflect physical load. A second objective was therefore to separate these two accounts by using mean heart rate as a covariate, so that an effect of manipulation counts as specific only if it exceeds what heart rate alone predicts. A third objective was to test whether the shift depends on the movement and on the participant's expertise. The same visible movement can be effortful and explicitly controlled in a novice and largely automatic in an experienced practitioner [18].

A further objective was to test the measurement pipeline itself. I built the capture system for this study from consumer hardware and open software. This makes it possible to compare the real-time α_1 reported by the streaming application with the estimate computed offline. Establishing how far these agree, and how robust α_1 is to the movement artifacts that object manipulation introduces, determines whether the stick can serve as a portable tool for studying states of skilled engagement outside the laboratory.

In summary, this thesis has three aims: (1) to test whether two minutes of stick manipulation shift α_1 relative to a standing baseline; (2) to test whether such a shift exceeds what the rise in heart rate predicts; and (3) to explore whether the shift depends on the movement and on expertise. In addition, it evaluates a portable recording pipeline that could support such measurements outside the laboratory.

The thesis is organised as follows. Section 2 reviews (1) cardiac autonomic control, (2) the method and interpretation of DFA α_1, (3) acute changes in α_1, (4) rhythmic coordination and the heart, (5) skill and flow, and (6) chest-strap recording. It closes with the hypotheses. Section 3 describes participants, design and the capture system; Section 4 the offline signal processing and statistics. Sections 5 to 7 report, discuss and summarise the results.

2 Background

2.1 Cardiac Autonomic Control and Heart Rate Variability

2.1.1 The heart under central control

The sinoatrial node sets the pace of the heart, but its rate is continuously adjusted by the two branches of the autonomic nervous system. Sympathetic outflow accelerates the heart and increases contractility through noradrenergic signalling with a latency of several seconds. Parasympathetic outflow through the vagus nerve slows the heart through acetylcholine acting on muscarinic receptors, with a latency short enough to influence the very next beat [44]. Because the two branches act on different time scales, the beat-to-beat timing of the heart carries information about both. Fast fluctuations are dominated by vagal activity, whereas slower fluctuations reflect a mixture of vagal, sympathetic, baroreflex and thermoregulatory influences.

This outflow is organised centrally. Benarroch [3] described a *central autonomic network* of reciprocally connected structures: the insular cortex, the anterior cingulate and ventromedial prefrontal cortex, the amygdala, the hypothalamus, the periaqueductal grey, the parabrachial complex and the nucleus of the solitary tract. These structures act on the medullary nuclei that generate sympathetic and vagal output. The network integrates visceral afferent information with descending signals related to emotion, attention and behaviour, and adjusts autonomic output accordingly. Its organisation has two properties that matter for the present thesis. First, it is distributed and hierarchical, so that autonomic output at any moment reflects the combined action of many loops. Second, its cortical components overlap with regions that support attention, error monitoring and self-regulation, so that cognitive and motor demands can shape autonomic output directly, in addition to the influence of metabolic need.

The ascending side of this circuitry is equally relevant. Interoceptive accounts place the insula at the centre of the brain's representation of bodily state [12]. Physiological signals are first represented in the posterior insula and then integrated into consciously accessible feelings in the anterior insula. On this view the heart is both regulated by and represented in the brain, and the regulation of cardiac rhythm is one component of a broader loop linking bodily state, feeling and action.

2.1.2 Neurovisceral integration

The neurovisceral integration model makes the link between cardiac regulation and cognition explicit [45]. It proposes that prefrontal circuits for attention and self-regulation inhibit subcortical circuits for threat and defence. The strength of this inhibition is expressed in the vagal control of the heart. High resting HRV is therefore taken to index a flexible system that adjusts quickly to changing demands. Low HRV indexes a system that struggles to leave a default defensive mode. A meta-analysis of neuroimaging studies supports the anatomical part of this account, showing that HRV is associated with activity in the ventromedial prefrontal cortex and the amygdala, among other regions [46].

For cognitive neuroscience, the attraction of this framework is practical as well as theoretical. HRV can be recorded non-invasively and continuously during a task, at a temporal resolution of single heartbeats, with equipment that does not constrain movement. It therefore offers a window on how the brain regulates the body during activities, such as object manipulation, that are difficult to

study with neuroimaging.

2.1.3 Amplitude indices of HRV and their limits

The standard indices of HRV quantify the amount of variability. In the time domain, the standard deviation of normal-to-normal intervals (SDNN) captures overall variability. The root mean square of successive differences (RMSSD) and the percentage of successive differences larger than 50 ms (pNN50) capture beat-to-beat variability, which is mainly vagal [44]. In the frequency domain, power in the high-frequency band (0.15–0.40 Hz) tracks respiratory sinus arrhythmia and vagal modulation, while low-frequency power (0.04–0.15 Hz) reflects a mixture of influences including the baroreflex [44]. Recommendations for psychophysiological research specify recording conditions, minimum durations and the control of confounds such as caffeine, recent exercise, posture and breathing [30].

However, amplitude indices have two limitations for the present question. First, they are strongly intensity-dependent, as vagal withdrawal at the onset of physical activity drives RMSSD and high-frequency power towards a floor, so that they lose resolution as soon as a task involves movement [21]. Second, the amount of variability does not distinguish a heartbeat that varies richly across time scales from one that varies in a simple, repetitive way. A strongly periodic signal, such as the large oscillations produced by slow paced breathing, yields high RMSSD and high spectral power but little complexity. Reflex tests illustrate the point from the opposite direction. For example, resting RMSSD shares only about half or less of its variance with other markers of cardiovagal function, such as the response to paced deep breathing or to standing up [6]. No single amplitude index captures autonomic regulation in full.

Taken together, HRV offers a continuous window on how the brain regulates the heart. Its amplitude indices, however, lose resolution during movement and say little about how variability is structured over time. The next section therefore turns to measures of organisation.

2.2 Fractal Physiology and Detrended Fluctuation Analysis

2.2.1 Complexity and health

Fractal physiology addresses the second limitation by asking how variability is organised across time scales. Many physiological signals show fluctuations that are self-similar across time scales, including the heartbeat, breathing and the stride intervals of walking [19, 22]. Their variability over a few seconds looks like their variability over minutes once it is rescaled. A healthy heart, for example, speeds up and slows down slightly with each breath, drifts over a minute as posture and attention change, and varies over hours with activity and sleep, and the pattern of change looks similar at each of these scales. In the heartbeat of healthy young adults, these fluctuations show long-range correlations close to $1/f$ behaviour, the boundary between uncorrelated noise and strongly correlated, Brownian-like drift [19, 35].

The key observation of this literature is that disease and ageing erode fractal organisation, and that they do so in two directions [19, 33]. Some conditions push the heartbeat towards uncorrelated randomness, in which each interval carries little information about the next. Others push it towards excessive regularity, in which a single dominant rhythm takes over, as in the strongly periodic heart rate oscillations of severe heart failure. In both cases the system loses the capacity to respond across many time scales at once. On this view, physiological health corresponds to adaptable organisation

across time scales, and a loss of complexity can be detected as a departure from the healthy scaling regime in either direction. Short-term fractal scaling also has clinical relevance, since a reduced short-term scaling exponent predicted mortality more strongly than traditional HRV indices in patients with depressed left ventricular function after myocardial infarction [26].

This framework connects naturally to biological robustness. Kitano [29] characterised robustness as a fundamental property of complex biological systems: the capacity to keep functioning under perturbation, through feedback control, modularity, redundancy and decoupling. A heartbeat regulated by many interacting loops operating on different time scales is, on this reading, the observable signature of a robust control architecture, and fractal scaling is one way of quantifying it. Network physiology extends the same idea to exercise, treating the organism as a network of interacting systems whose coupling reorganises with physical and cognitive demands [1].

2.2.2 Computing DFA

Detrended fluctuation analysis was introduced to quantify correlations in non-stationary time series such as heartbeat recordings [35]. For a series of N RR intervals RR_i with mean $\overline{RR}$, the series is first integrated,

$$y(k) = \sum_{i=1}^{k} \left(RR_i - \overline{RR} \right), \qquad k = 1, \ldots, N. \tag{1}$$

The integrated series is divided into non-overlapping boxes of length n beats. In each box a least-squares line $y_n(k)$ is fitted and subtracted, which removes local trends. The root-mean-square fluctuation of the detrended series,

$$F(n) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum_{k=1}^{N} \left[y(k) - y_n(k) \right]^2}, \tag{2}$$

is computed for a range of box sizes. If the series is fractal, $F(n)$ grows as a power of n, $F(n) \propto n^{\alpha}$, and the scaling exponent α is the slope of $\log F(n)$ against $\log n$. Consider a participant resting at about 70 beats per minute. A two-minute window then contains about 140 RR intervals, which yields 35 boxes of four beats and eight boxes of sixteen beats. If the fluctuation function doubles when the box size quadruples from 4 to 16 beats, the slope in log–log coordinates is 0.5, the value expected for uncorrelated noise; if it quadruples, the slope is 1.0. Heartbeat series typically show a crossover between short and long time scales, so two exponents are estimated: α_1 over box sizes of 4 to 16 beats and α_2 over 16 to 64 beats [35]. The present thesis concerns α_1, which can be estimated from short recordings and changes within minutes.

2.2.3 Interpreting α_1

What does a given value of α_1 mean physiologically? The value of α maps onto classes of signal. An uncorrelated series (white noise) gives $\alpha = 0.5$, a series with $1/f$ correlations gives $\alpha = 1.0$, and Brownian motion, the integral of white noise, gives $\alpha = 1.5$. Values between 0.5 and 1.0 indicate persistent but stationary correlations, and values between 1.0 and 1.5 indicate increasingly non-stationary, drift-dominated behaviour. Hoos and Gronwald [25] argue that these values should be read against two classes of signal: fractional Gaussian noise (fGN, $\alpha < 1$) and fractional Brownian motion (fBM, $\alpha > 1$). The healthy resting heartbeat sits near the boundary between the two. On

this reading, $\alpha_1 \approx 0.75$ marks the midpoint of the fGN range, and $\alpha_1 \approx 0.5$ marks the loss of short-term correlation. Table 1 summarises the landmarks used throughout this thesis.

Table 1: Landmark values of the short-term scaling exponent α_1.

α_1	Signal class	Typical physiological context
≈ 1.5	Brownian-like, strongly correlated drift	Excessive regularity, e.g. slow periodic oscillations dominating the series [19]
≈ 1.0	$1/f$, boundary of fGN and fBM	Healthy rest and very low exercise intensity [21]
≈ 0.75	Midpoint of the fGN range	First ventilatory threshold in incremental exercise [37]
≈ 0.5	Uncorrelated (white noise)	High exercise intensity; loss of organisation [20]

2.2.4 Window length, detrending and reference settings

Because α_1 spans only 4 to 16 beats, it can be estimated from short recordings, but the estimate becomes unstable when too few boxes are available. In exercise research, α_1 is commonly computed over a two-minute window, recomputed every few seconds as the window slides along the recording [36, 37]. The two-minute convention is supported by analyses of how data length and non-stationarity affect DFA estimates [11] [verify: exact claim in Chen et al. on minimum length]. At the heart rates seen in light activity, two minutes correspond to roughly 120 to 200 beats. The present study adopts the two-minute window because it is also close to the longest duration for which a skilled manipulation movement can be sustained without breaking off.

Two further settings affect the estimate, the first of which is the detrending of the RR series before DFA. Reference implementations, including the widely used Kubios software, apply smoothness-priors detrending [43] with a smoothing parameter of $\lambda = 500$ to remove very slow trends that would otherwise inflate the fluctuation function [36]. The second is the treatment of artifacts, as missed, extra and ectopic beats distort α_1 more strongly than amplitude indices, and artifact rates above a few percent bias the estimate [36]. Hoos and Gronwald [25] argue that these settings, together with window length and box-size range, need to be standardised and reported explicitly before α_1 values can be compared between studies. Section 4 specifies the settings used here.

Taken together, α_1 summarises the short-range correlation structure of the heartbeat in a single exponent with interpretable landmarks, provided that window length, detrending and artifact handling are fixed and reported.

2.3 Acute Changes in DFA α_1

2.3.1 Rest versus activity

Karasik et al. [27] were among the first to report that correlations in heartbeat fluctuations differ between rest and exercise, with the short-range structure changing more than the long-range structure [verify: direction and scale of the effect in Karasik et al.]. Subsequent exercise research established that α_1 decreases systematically with increasing intensity. A systematic review found this pattern consistently across endurance exercise studies, in which α_1 sat around 1.0 at rest and low intensity, fell through the moderate range and approached 0.5 or below at high intensity [20]. The decline is generally interpreted as a loss of correlation as the multiple regulatory influences on the heart are progressively

replaced by a dominant drive from central command and metabolic feedback [1, 21].

2.3.2 α_1 as an intensity marker

The intensity dependence of α_1 has made it a candidate biomarker for exercise prescription. Rogers et al. [37] proposed that the heart rate at which α_1 crosses 0.75 during an incremental test approximates the first ventilatory threshold, the boundary between low and moderate intensity. Later work broadened this to a general account of α_1 as a marker of intensity distribution in training [21, 36]. However, the proposal has been challenged. For example, Cassirame et al. [9] examined DFA-derived thresholds in an incremental cycling test and questioned how reliably they match physiological thresholds in individuals [verify: exact findings of Cassirame et al.]. Hoos and Gronwald [25] cautioned that fixed cut-offs depend on reference settings that are not yet standardised. For the present thesis, the relevant point is that α_1 responds within minutes to changes in physiological state.

2.3.3 Beyond intensity

A smaller body of work shows that α_1 also responds to factors other than momentary intensity. In ultramarathon runners, α_1 measured at the same low running intensity was lower after the race than before it, suggesting that fatigue alters the organisation of heart rate regulation independently of workload [38]. Short-term DFA has also been applied to psychological stress paradigms [todo: find and add a verified source on short-term DFA under cognitive or psychological stress]. These findings matter for the present question because they show that two conditions with the same heart rate can differ in α_1. This is the logic on which the heart-rate adjustment in the present design rests.

What is missing from this literature is a task in which physical intensity is low but attentional and motor demands are high. Almost all acute α_1 studies concern endurance exercise, in which intensity and regulatory demand rise together. Object manipulation decouples the two: it raises heart rate only modestly but demands continuous visuomotor prediction and fine force control.

Taken together, α_1 responds within minutes to changes in physiological state, and it can differ between two conditions with the same heart rate. What remains untested is a task that is light on the body and heavy on control.

2.4 Rhythmic Movement, Sound and Cardiorespiratory Coupling

2.4.1 Locomotor–respiratory coupling

Rhythmic movement interacts with the body's other rhythms, and during walking, running, cycling, rowing and wheelchair propulsion, breathing tends to lock into stable frequency ratios with the movement cycle, a phenomenon called locomotor–respiratory coupling (LRC) [5, 7]. In quadrupeds, coupling is enforced mechanically by the loading of the thorax with each stride [7]; in humans it is weaker and more variable, and its strength differs between individuals and tasks [5]. Bardy et al. [2] distinguish three sources of coupling: mechanical interactions, such as the displacement of the viscera with each step; neurophysiological interactions, such as afferent signals from moving limbs reaching respiratory centres in the brainstem; and informational interactions, such as external rhythms the person attends to.

LRC can be modelled as the interaction of two coupled nonlinear oscillators. Hoffmann et al. [24] used the sine circle map, in which the ratio of the two frequencies (the winding number) and the

strength of the coupling determine whether the system settles into a stable mode-locked ratio. The stable ratios are ordered in a Farey tree, in which low-order ratios such as 1:2 occupy wider regions of stability than high-order ratios, and are therefore more resistant to perturbation [23, 24].

2.4.2 Sound-induced stabilisation

External sound can strengthen this coupling, as shown in a cycling study in which participants synchronised either their pedalling or their breathing with a metronome set to their own preferred frequency [24]. Auditory pacing stabilised LRC and was accompanied by a significant reduction in energy expenditure. The effect was asymmetrical: pacing the pedalling stabilised coupling more than pacing the breathing. When participants cycled in time with the tone, their breathing shifted towards more stable frequency ratios, as the sine circle map predicts. A follow-up study varied the frequency of pacing [23]. Sound stabilised LRC at all frequencies tested and for both paced systems. The effect was strongest at the participant's preferred rhythm, and frequencies far from it led to a loss of stability. The authors concluded that coupling runs in both directions, from movement to breathing and from breathing to movement.

Bardy et al. [2] reviewed both studies and drew out the role of the starting state. Sound stabilised participants whose coupling was initially unstable, and it could destabilise those whose coupling was already stable [verify: whether this is reported in Bardy et al. 2015 or Hoffmann et al. 2012]. The effect of rhythmic information therefore depends on how well coordinated the person already is, which is precisely the kind of individual difference that expertise might produce.

2.4.3 Music, rhythm and the heart

The cardiovascular effects of music have been studied for decades, with results that range from careful laboratory physiology to broad clinical claims. Narrative reviews conclude that music can modulate heart rate, blood pressure, HRV and stress hormones, but that effects depend on the music and the listener and that the underlying mechanisms remain poorly understood [10, 47]. Some of these reviews go further, recommending particular composers and warning against particular genres [47]; such claims rest on limited evidence and are noted here as context only. A randomised controlled study gives a more measured picture [48]. Twenty-five minutes of music by Mozart or Strauss lowered blood pressure and heart rate, whereas music by ABBA did not. Serum cortisol decreased in all groups, including a control group resting in silence.

Laboratory work on tempo is more directly relevant. Faster music elicits greater sympathetic arousal, measured as skin conductance, than slower music [16]. Skin conductance responses are also more frequent during music than during silence, consistent with musical beats capturing attention. Bernardi et al. [4] recorded heart rate, respiration, blood pressure, cerebral blood flow velocity and skin vasomotion while 24 young adults, half of them trained choristers, listened to music with different profiles. Crescendos raised blood pressure and constricted skin blood vessels in proportion to their intensity, and uniform emphasis did the reverse. Musical phrases repeating about every ten seconds, close to the 0.1 Hz rhythm of blood-pressure Mayer waves, entrained cardiovascular variables. Notably, the responses did not differ qualitatively between musicians and non-musicians. A recent review in the Cambridge Elements series integrates such findings into an account of how auditory rhythm interacts with cardiac, respiratory and motor rhythms in perception and action [50]. Wearable sensing now allows these relations to be measured outside the laboratory; for example, an

earable system predicted the direction of physiological change during music listening from vital signs alone in about 70% of cases [8].

Rhythmic activity shared between people can couple their hearts as well. When pairs of non-experts vocalised together, their HRV became more coupled during long, synchronous notes than during short notes or at baseline [39]. Most of this coupling was attributable to respiratory sinus arrhythmia, but part of it persisted after the influence of breathing was removed, and the frequency of vocal onsets matched the frequency at which coupling peaked. Coupling did not, however, map clearly onto participants' subjective sense of togetherness.

2.4.4 Implications for an upper-limb rhythmic task

Three conclusions follow for the present study. First, rhythmic movement and rhythmic sound both have documented routes to cardiorespiratory rhythms, mainly via breathing and respiratory sinus arrhythmia, with some coupling remaining once breathing is accounted for [39]. Second, the stick's figure-eight motion is a rhythmic upper-limb movement without the impact loading of locomotion, so any coupling it produces is likely to be mainly neurophysiological and informational [2]. Third, the effect of rhythmic information depends on the starting state of the person, which motivates measuring expertise. The present study records cardiac dynamics only, without a breathing signal or a metronome, and asks whether a downstream signature of coupling is visible there. Coupling serves as one candidate mechanism among several, alongside effort, attention and arousal, and the discussion returns to how it could be isolated in future work.

2.5 Skill, Expertise and Flow

2.5.1 Object manipulation as a model of skill

Object manipulation has a place in cognitive neuroscience as a model of skill learning. Three months of juggling practice produced transient increases in grey matter in the mid-temporal visual motion area hMT/V5 and the left posterior intraparietal sulcus, which partly reversed when practice stopped [17]. Six weeks of juggling training changed white-matter architecture beneath the right posterior intraparietal sulcus [41]. These studies established juggling as a model of experience-dependent plasticity, although their focus is structural and long-term. They say little about the state of the person while manipulating an object, which is the focus here.

Classical accounts describe skill acquisition in three stages [18]. In the *cognitive* stage, the learner works out what to do; movement is effortful, error-prone and under explicit attentional control. In the *associative* stage, errors fall and movement becomes more consistent as the learner refines the mapping between intention and outcome. In the *autonomous* stage, movement runs with little conscious control, freeing attention for other demands. A stick-naive participant performing an isolation for the first time is in the cognitive stage; an experienced practitioner performing the same movement is close to autonomy. The same visible movement can therefore correspond to very different internal states, and any physiological measurement of practice has to take expertise into account.

The two movements in this study differ along the same lines. Isolations demand that one point of the stick stay fixed in space while the hand travels around it, which requires continuous visual feedback and fine corrections. Spins are faster and, once learned, more self-sustaining, because

the rotation carries momentum, and the hand's role shifts from placing the stick to maintaining a rhythm. Isolations thus load prediction and control, whereas spins load rhythm and timing, and expertise is expected to change both, possibly in different ways.

2.5.2 The psychophysiology of flow

Flow denotes a state of complete absorption in an activity whose challenge matches one's skill, accompanied by a merging of action and awareness, a sense of control and a loss of self-consciousness [13]. Its physiology has mostly been studied with amplitude measures. For example, in expert pianists playing familiar pieces, flow was associated with higher heart rate, deeper breathing and activity of the smiling muscle (zygomaticus major) [14] [verify: exact physiological findings in de Manzano et al.]. The authors read this as positive affect combined with effortful attention. In a task matched to participants' skill, the matched condition came with lower HRV and higher salivary cortisol than boredom or overload [28] [verify: direction of HRV and cortisol effects in Keller et al.]. Peifer et al. [34] brought these findings together by showing that flow relates to sympathetic arousal in an inverted U and to parasympathetic activity positively, suggesting co-activation of both autonomic branches during flow.

Neurocognitive accounts point in a compatible direction. Specifically, the transient hypofrontality hypothesis proposes that flow involves a temporary down-regulation of explicit, prefrontally mediated control, allowing implicit, well-practised processes to run with less interference [15]. Imaging of experimentally induced flow, using a task adaptively matched to each participant's skill, found reduced activity in the medial prefrontal cortex and amygdala and increased activity in the inferior frontal gyrus and putamen [49]. The medial prefrontal cortex and amygdala are precisely the regions implicated in neurovisceral integration (Section 2.1), which gives a plausible anatomical route from a flow-like state to cardiac regulation.

2.5.3 The case for a complexity marker

Correlation structure may capture co-activation of competing autonomic inputs, a pattern that amplitude indices summarise poorly. If a state of skilled absorption involves several regulatory loops operating together, its signature should appear in how heart rate variation is organised, which is what α_1 quantifies. Inducing flow is outside the primary aim of the present study, and participants include novices for whom the task is unlikely to produce it. Flow nevertheless motivates the choice of α_1 as the outcome and the inclusion of expertise as a factor. If the organisation of cardiac regulation during manipulation changes with skill, experts are where a flow-related signature would first be expected.

Taken together, skill learning and flow both predict that the same movement can engage cardiac regulation differently depending on expertise. This prediction has not yet been tested with a measure of complexity.

2.6 Measuring RR Intervals Outside the Laboratory

Electrocardiography (ECG) is the reference method for recording RR intervals, but chest-strap sensors are now widely used in research because they are cheap, portable and tolerate movement. The Polar H10 records a single-lead ECG through electrodes in the strap and transmits RR intervals at a resolution of 1/1024 s over Bluetooth Low Energy.

Two validation studies frame its use here. Schaffarczyk et al. [40] compared the H10 with simultaneous ECG in 25 recreational athletes during rest and an incremental cycling test to exhaustion. Agreement was high at rest before and after exercise (e.g. $r = 0.95$ and ICC $= 0.95$ for α_1 before exercise) and correlations remained above 0.93 during exercise. During exercise, however, all variables showed a statistically significant bias. For RR intervals and heart rate, bias and limits of agreement were negligible. For α_1, they widened with intensity: from a bias of 0.9–8.6% with limits of agreement of +11.6 to −9.9% at low intensity, to limits of +58.1 to −40.9% at high intensity. α_1 values in the uncorrelated range, below about 0.5, were the least reliable. Blalock et al. [6] compared the H10 with ECG in 43 healthy young adults during supine rest, paced deep breathing and active standing. Agreement for mean RR interval, RMSSD, SDNN and standard reflex tests was excellent (concordance correlation ≥ 0.99, mean absolute percentage error below 1%, 95% limits of agreement within about ± 1.7 ms). The authors concluded that the H10 is effectively interchangeable with laboratory ECG for these measures.

Two implications follow. For RR intervals and amplitude indices at rest and during light activity, the H10 can be treated as equivalent to ECG. For α_1, it is valid at rest and at low intensity, which is the range expected during stick manipulation, but its error grows with intensity and with movement of the upper body, which object manipulation introduces. Artifact rates must therefore be reported per trial, and agreement between the real-time and offline α_1 estimates is itself a question for the present study.

Taken together, the H10 is a valid tool for this study as long as the movement stays light and data quality is checked trial by trial.

2.7 Research Gap

The review identifies three gaps. First, with regard to the *domain*, research on acute changes in α_1 concerns endurance exercise, in which physical intensity and regulatory demand rise together; brief, attention-demanding motor skills at low intensity have not been studied. Second, with regard to the *index*, the psychophysiology of flow and skilled engagement relies on amplitude indices such as RMSSD and high-frequency power, and the organisation of variability during skilled action has not been examined. Third, with regard to *expertise*, both the coupling literature and the skill literature show that the same input or movement affects people differently depending on their starting state. No study has asked whether the cardiac signature of a movement depends on expertise with it.

Underlying all three is a methodological problem. Because α_1 falls with exercise intensity, any change during a movement task could reflect physical load alone. A study of skilled manipulation must therefore treat heart rate as a covariate, so that an effect counts as specific only if it exceeds what heart rate alone predicts. For example, suppose a participant's heart rate rises from 75 to 90 beats per minute during spins and their α_1 drops from 1.05 to 0.85. If the same 15-beat rise during light cycling typically lowers α_1 by about the same amount, the spins add nothing beyond load. If α_1 drops much further than that, something about the skill itself is at work [todo: replace the illustrative numbers with pilot values].

2.8 Hypotheses

Young, healthy participants are likely to rest near $\alpha_1 \approx 1.0$, which leaves little room for an *increase* to be interpreted as an improvement. I therefore formulate the hypotheses in terms of direction and specificity, and read them with the two-directional complexity framework (Section 2.2): (1) a shift towards 0.5 indicates a loss of short-term correlation; (2) a shift towards 1.5 indicates increasing regularity; (3) stability near 1.0 indicates preserved organisation under task demand. All hypotheses were specified before the main sample was collected [confirm: pre-registration with Timo, date and platform].

Specifically, I hypothesised that mean α_1 during stick manipulation differs from α_1 during a standing baseline in which the participant holds the stick still (Hypothesis 1). As no direction was predicted, this is tested two-sided, and the direction of the shift and the position of task values relative to the landmarks 0.5, 0.75 and 1.0 are reported regardless of significance.

Furthermore, as α_1 falls with exercise intensity, a shift during manipulation may reflect physical load alone. I therefore hypothesised that the shift during manipulation exceeds what the accompanying rise in heart rate predicts, and that this specific component differs between isolations and spins (Hypothesis 2). Spins are faster and more rhythmic, so I expect heart rate to explain most of their shift. Isolations are slow, precise and visually guided, so any shift beyond heart rate would point to regulatory engagement.

Finally, I expected expertise to moderate the shift (Hypothesis 3). Less experienced participants are closer to the cognitive stage of skill, so the same movement demands more explicit control from them. At comparable heart rate, they should therefore depart further from their baseline α_1 than highly practised participants. Because the sample consists mainly of experienced practitioners, expertise is tested as a continuous score, and the few novices are compared with the experienced group descriptively.

I examine three further questions without a directional hypothesis: (1) whether α_1 at the second baseline differs from the first (carry-over); (2) how closely the real-time α_1 of the streaming application agrees with the offline estimate; and (3) whether the dominant and non-dominant hand differ.

3 Methods

3.1 Participants

I collected data in two phases. In the first phase (October 2026), five participants completed the full protocol; these recordings also served to check data quality and to fix the remaining protocol parameters. In the second phase (November and December 2026), about ten further participants were recruited. The sample consists mainly of experienced practitioners who can sustain both movements for two minutes, together with a small number of novices for comparison [confirm: final N per group and recruitment channels]. The target sample was therefore $N \approx 15$, of whom about three to five are novices.

Inclusion criteria were age between 18 and 45 years, no known cardiovascular, respiratory or neurological condition, and the ability to perform both movements with each hand for two minutes. Stick-naive participants received a short standardised instruction and practice period before recording

(Section 3.3). Exclusion criteria were arrhythmia, an implanted cardiac device, pregnancy, and medication known to affect heart rate or HRV, such as beta-blockers. Participants were asked to avoid caffeine for two hours and strenuous exercise for 24 hours before the session, and to avoid a heavy meal in the preceding two hours [30]. Compliance with these requests and other known influences on HRV were recorded in a pre-session questionnaire (Section 3.6).

I assessed expertise in the same questionnaire with four items: (1) years of practice with the stick and with other flow-arts props; (2) practice hours per week; (3) a self-rating of proficiency for each movement from 1 to 10; and (4) whether the participant can sustain each movement for two minutes without dropping the stick. Participants who reported regular practice and could sustain both movements formed the experienced group; all others formed the novice group [confirm: grouping rule]. Because novices are few, expertise is analysed primarily as a continuous score derived from these items, and the contrast between groups is reported descriptively (Section 4.5).

Recruiting mainly experienced practitioners follows from the research question. The primary comparison is within each participant, between a movement and that participant's own baseline, so expertise does not bias it. Experienced practitioners can sustain the movements for the full two minutes with few drops, which yields continuous movement bouts and cleaner recordings, and their data describe the effect of the movement as it is actually practised. Novices add a contrast, as they perform the same movement in an early, effortful stage of learning. The cost of this choice is generalisability, discussed in Section 6.6.

All participants gave written informed consent. [todo: ethics: name the approving committee or state that the study falls under the unit's existing approval; add reference number]

With a paired design, $N = 15$ provides 80% power to detect a within-participant effect of $d \approx 0.78$ at $\alpha = .05$ (two-sided). Effects smaller than this, and all between-group comparisons of expertise, are therefore reported as estimates with confidence intervals.

3.2 The Stick and the Movements

The isolation stick was created more than 20 years ago by Alexandre "Pich", a French artist and manipulation specialist with Le Cirque Graphique, influenced by Michael Moschen's work on rhythm and motion [todo: source]. The stick used here is about 50 cm long with a weight at each end [confirm: exact length, mass and material]. The weighting moves the centre of mass outwards and gives the stick rotational inertia, so that once set in motion it tends to continue in a figure-eight path around the hand. The design comes from a movement practice that treats structured variability as the basis of skilled coordination: movement that keeps a recognisable pattern while varying slightly from cycle to cycle [confirm: whether to cite the EightOS / seks.design material here].

I recorded two families of movement. In an *isolation*, one point of the stick, typically its centre or one end, is held fixed in space while the hand and the rest of the stick move around it. Isolations are slow, demand continuous visual monitoring and fine force control, and break down visibly when control lapses. In a *spin*, the stick rotates continuously around the hand or fingers in a figure-eight. Spins are faster, rely mainly on timing and momentum, and produce a regular rhythm once established. Each movement was performed with the left and with the right hand. Participants were instructed to keep the movement going for the whole trial at a pace they could sustain, to restart immediately after a drop, and to breathe naturally. Drops were counted by the experimenter.

3.3 Experimental Paradigm

The study used a within-participant design with one factor, *condition*, at three levels (baseline, isolation, spin), and expertise as a between-participant variable, measured as a continuous score and summarised as novice or experienced. Hand (left, right) was recorded within each movement condition and treated as a secondary factor.

Because both movements are performed standing, the control condition was a standing baseline, during which participants stood still, holding the stick at rest in the hand, for the same duration as a movement trial. This baseline matches posture and grip, so the comparison between baseline and movement isolates the movement itself. A seated baseline would confound movement with posture, since moving from sitting to standing on its own lowers vagally mediated HRV [30]. Each participant was their own control. Table 2 summarises the role of each condition.

Table 2: Conditions and their role in the design.

Condition	What the participant does	Role	Compared with
Pre-task baseline	stands still holding the stick, 2 min	control	each movement trial
Isolation, left and right	isolations with one hand, 2 min each	test	baseline; spins
Spin, left and right	spins with one hand, 2 min each	test	baseline; isolations
Recovery	stands still after each trial	washout, not analysed	
Post-task baseline	as the pre-task baseline	carry-over check	pre-task baseline

Each session followed the sequence in Table 3. After consent, questionnaires and fitting of the chest strap, participants stood still holding the stick for the pre-task baseline. The four movement trials (isolation left, isolation right, spin left, spin right) followed in an order counterbalanced across participants [confirm: counterbalancing scheme: Latin square vs randomised]. Each movement trial was followed by a recovery period of standing still, so that every trial started from a comparable state [confirm: standing vs seated recovery]. A post-task baseline, identical to the first, closed the session.

Table 3: Session timeline. Durations in square brackets are still to be fixed from the first-phase data.

Step	Duration	Content
1	10 min	Consent, pre-session questionnaire (about 2 min), strap fitting, signal check
2	5 min	Familiarisation: practice of both movements with each hand (novices); warm-up (experienced)
3	2 min	Pre-task baseline: standing still, holding the stick, eyes open
4	4×2 min	Movement trials (isolation and spin, each hand), counterbalanced order
	[2 min] each	Recovery, standing still, after each movement trial
5	2 min	Post-task baseline, as in step 3
6	5 min	Post-session ratings and debrief
	$\approx$ 45 min	Total

The trial duration of two minutes was chosen as a compromise between two constraints. α_1 is

conventionally estimated from a two-minute window (Section 2.2), so shorter trials would not yield a stable estimate. Longer trials, in turn, exceed the duration for which isolations in particular can be sustained without fatigue of the forearm and repeated drops, which would turn the trial into a series of restarts. [confirm: 2 min vs 3 min: if trials are extended to 3 min, α_1 is taken from the final 2 min so that the onset transient is excluded]

I recorded baselines with the same system and duration as the movement trials. Baseline and movement estimates are therefore based on comparable amounts of data. The pre-task baseline is the reference for H1; the post-task baseline serves the carry-over analysis.

3.4 Technical Setup

Figure 1 gives an overview of the recording chain. I recorded RR intervals with a Polar H10 chest strap (Polar Electro, Kempele, Finland) worn at the level of the lower sternum with moistened electrodes. The H10 transmits RR intervals at a resolution of 1/1024 s through the standard Bluetooth Low Energy Heart Rate Measurement characteristic, in which a single notification can carry several RR values.

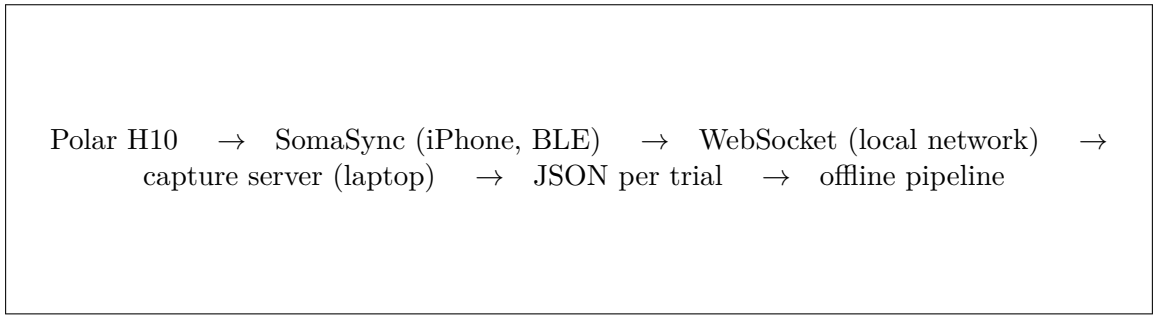


Figure 1: Recording chain. [todo: replace with a drawn diagram and a photo of the setup]

A first version of the setup connected the H10 directly to a browser page through the Web Bluetooth interface. On the laptop used for recording, this connection repeatedly dropped within seconds of being established, so the final setup routed the signal through a phone. I paired the H10 with the SomaSync application on an iPhone [confirm: app version]. The application keeps the Bluetooth connection stable and streams each RR interval, with its own real-time HRV metrics, over the local network.

A custom capture server (Node.js) running on the laptop received this stream. Its web interface, opened in a browser on the same laptop, allowed the experimenter to enter the participant identifier, the condition label and the trial duration before starting each trial. The server time-stamped each RR interval on arrival and stopped the trial automatically when the set duration had elapsed. Every trial therefore had the same length without manual timing. Each trial was saved as one file containing the RR intervals with timestamps and the trial details. A second file kept a raw log of every message received. Keeping the raw log means that any value reported by the streaming application can be recomputed or checked later. The code for the capture server and the analysis pipeline is available in the project repository [todo: repository link or archive DOI].

3.5 Real-time Metrics

In addition to the raw RR intervals, SomaSync reports its own running estimates of heart rate, RMSSD, SDNN, pNN50 and α_1, which were stored with each trial. The settings behind these estimates (window length, detrending, artifact handling) are not documented in enough detail to be reproduced [confirm: check with SomaSync documentation or developer]. They were therefore not used for the primary analyses. Instead, they were compared with the offline estimates computed from the same RR intervals (Section 4.5), which tests whether a consumer application can stand in for an offline pipeline in future, larger studies.

3.6 Questionnaires

Before the session, participants completed a short questionnaire that takes about two minutes (Appendix 8.3). Table 4 lists its blocks and how each enters the analysis.

Table 4: Pre-session questionnaire and its use in the analysis.

Block	Items	Use
Demographics	age, sex, height, weight	description of the sample; age as a covariate, since complexity declines with age [19]
Fitness	hours of physical exercise per week	interpretation of the heart-rate response (H2)
State on the day	caffeine in the last 2 h, alcohol in the last 24 h, strenuous exercise in the last 24 h, hours of sleep, smoking, medication	exclusion and sensitivity analyses for H1–H3 [30]
Handedness	dominant hand	coding of dominant and non-dominant hand (exploratory)
Expertise	years with the stick, years with other props, hours per week, self-rated proficiency per movement, can sustain each movement for 2 min	expertise score and grouping (H3)

After each movement trial, participants rated perceived difficulty and perceived exertion [confirm: scales: e.g. Borg CR10 for exertion], and after the session they completed a short flow questionnaire for each movement [confirm: instrument, e.g. Flow Short Scale]. These ratings are used descriptively and in exploratory analyses only.

4 Offline Data Analysis

I ran all offline analyses in Python (NumPy, SciPy, statsmodels) with a pipeline I wrote for this study. The pipeline reads each trial file, corrects artifacts, computes HRV metrics and α_1, and stores the results in a local database [todo: versions of Python and packages]. A browser dashboard shows each trial next to the metrics reported in real time by the streaming application.

4.1 Preprocessing

I took RR intervals in the order received and converted them to milliseconds. I identified artifacts in two steps. First, intervals outside 300–2000 ms, corresponding to heart rates outside about

30–200 beats per minute, were marked as physiologically implausible. Second, each remaining interval was compared with the last accepted interval, and intervals differing from it by more than 20% were marked as artifacts. This percentage rule catches missed beats, extra beats and most ectopic beats. Marked intervals were replaced by linear interpolation between the neighbouring accepted intervals, which keeps the series continuous and preserves its length, as DFA requires.

I computed the proportion of corrected intervals for every trial and report it in Section 5. α_1 is more sensitive to artifacts than amplitude indices, and its bias becomes relevant above a few percent [36]. I therefore excluded trials with more than 5% corrected intervals from the analyses of α_1 [confirm: threshold: 5% vs 3%]. A sensitivity analysis repeated the main models with a stricter threshold of 3%.

4.2 Heart Rate and Amplitude Indices

For each trial the pipeline computed mean heart rate as $60\,000/\overline{RR}$ (beats per minute), SDNN as the standard deviation of the corrected RR intervals, RMSSD as

$$\mathrm{RMSSD} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1}\sum_{i=1}^{N-1}(RR_{i+1} - RR_i)^2}, \tag{3}$$

and pNN50 as the percentage of successive differences larger than 50 ms [44]. These indices are reported alongside α_1 to allow comparison with earlier work on flow and skilled performance, which has relied on them, and mean heart rate enters the models as the covariate that indexes physical load.

4.3 DFA α_1

I computed α_1 following Peng et al. [35], as described in Section 2.2. The corrected RR series was integrated after subtraction of its mean and divided into non-overlapping boxes for each box size $n = 4, 5, \ldots, 16$ beats. In each box a linear trend was fitted by least squares and removed, and the fluctuation function $F(n)$ was computed as the root mean square of the residuals across all boxes. α_1 was the slope of a least-squares line fitted to $\log F(n)$ against $\log n$. Estimates were not computed for series shorter than 64 beats, which ensures at least four boxes at the largest box size.

The primary outcome was a single α_1 value per trial, computed over the full two-minute trial. To describe how α_1 evolved within longer recordings, the pipeline also computed a sliding-window estimate over windows of 120 beats moved in steps of 30 beats. These within-trial traces are used descriptively only, because a two-minute trial contains essentially one independent estimate, so within-trial dynamics cannot be tested.

Two settings differ from the reference implementation used in most exercise studies and were aligned with it before the final analysis [confirm: implemented and re-run]. First, smoothness-priors detrending with $\lambda = 500$ [43] was applied to the RR series before DFA, to remove slow trends in heart rate that would otherwise inflate the fluctuation function at the larger box sizes. Second, the sliding-window traces were defined in time (two-minute windows, recomputed every 5 s), so that windows contain comparable durations of data across conditions with different heart rates [36]. Results with both the original and the aligned settings are reported, so that the effect of these choices is visible [25].

4.4 Pilot Checks

I used the first recordings to check the pipeline end to end. They confirmed that trials started and stopped at the set duration, that RR intervals arrived without gaps over the WebSocket link, and that the dashboard reproduced the files on disk. They also showed that the real-time α_1 reported by the streaming application could differ noticeably from the offline estimate for the same trial; in one baseline recording, for example, the two values were 1.21 and 1.48. Differences of this size are large relative to the shifts expected between conditions, which is why the primary analyses use the offline estimate only and the agreement between the two is analysed formally (Section 4.5). [confirm: the first recordings used a seated baseline; record a standing baseline for these participants or analyse them separately] [todo: summarise artifact rates and heart rates from the first five participants once processed]

4.5 Statistics

Table 5 summarises the analysis plan. All models were linear mixed-effects models with a random intercept per participant, fitted by restricted maximum likelihood; fixed effects were tested with Wald tests and reported with 95% confidence intervals. Movement trials were averaged across hands for H1 and H3 and entered separately for H2, with hand as a covariate. Model assumptions were checked with residual plots; where residuals departed clearly from normality, results were checked with a non-parametric test on per-participant means.

Table 5: Analysis plan. $\Delta\alpha_1$ is the α_1 of a movement trial minus the participant's pre-task baseline value.

Question	Outcome	Model
H1: task vs baseline	α_1	condition (baseline, isolation, spin) + random intercept; paired t-test on per-participant means as check
Direction of shift	$\Delta\alpha_1$	sign test on the number of participants whose α_1 rises vs falls; position of task values relative to 0.5, 0.75, 1.0
H2: isolation vs spin	α_1	movement + mean HR + hand + random intercept (movement trials only)
H3: expertise	$\lvert\Delta\alpha_1\rvert$	expertise score + ΔHR + movement + random intercept; novices vs experienced described separately
Carry-over	α_1	post-task vs pre-task baseline, paired
Hand	α_1	dominant vs non-dominant hand, coded by handedness (exploratory)
Agreement	α_1	Bland–Altman analysis, real-time vs offline estimate

For H1, the contrast of interest was baseline versus movement, with the two movement levels compared with the baseline separately and jointly. Because no direction was predicted, the direction of the shift was reported for every participant, and the proportion of increases and decreases was tested with a sign test. For H2, mean heart rate as a covariate tests whether isolations and spins still differ once their difference in physical load is accounted for. I repeated this analysis with the change in heart rate from baseline as the covariate. For H3, I used the absolute change in α_1 because no direction was predicted. The heart-rate change entered as a covariate, so that a larger change in less experienced participants could not simply reflect greater effort.

I corrected H2 and H3 for multiple comparisons with the Holm procedure. Exploratory analyses (carry-over, hand, agreement, and relations with questionnaire ratings) were not corrected and are reported as estimates with 95% confidence intervals. I assessed agreement between real-time

and offline α_1 with Bland–Altman analysis, reporting the mean difference (bias) and 95% limits of agreement. I also checked whether the difference depended on the size of α_1, as reported for the H10 against ECG [40].

5 Results

[todo: write after data collection; planned structure below]

5.1 Data Quality and Sample

[todo: final N per group; trials recorded and excluded; artifact percentage per condition (table); drops per movement trial]

5.2 Descriptive Statistics

[todo: table: mean HR, RMSSD, SDNN, pNN50 and α_1 per condition and expertise group, mean (SD)]

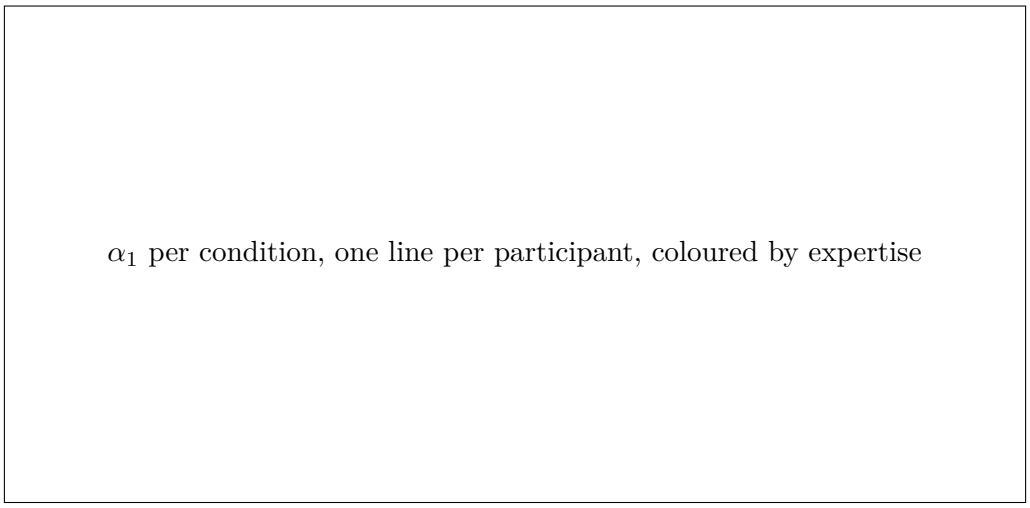


Figure 2: [todo: Figure 2]

5.3 Hypothesis 1: Does Stick Manipulation Shift α_1?

[todo: model estimates; direction counts; position relative to 0.5, 0.75, 1.0]

5.4 Hypothesis 2: Does the Shift Exceed What Heart Rate Explains?

[todo: model with mean HR; figure of $\Delta\alpha_1$ against ΔHR coloured by movement]

5.5 Hypothesis 3: Does the Shift Depend on Expertise?

[todo: group comparison and continuous analysis]

5.6 Exploratory Analyses

[todo: carry-over; hand; Bland–Altman of real-time vs offline α_1; questionnaire ratings]

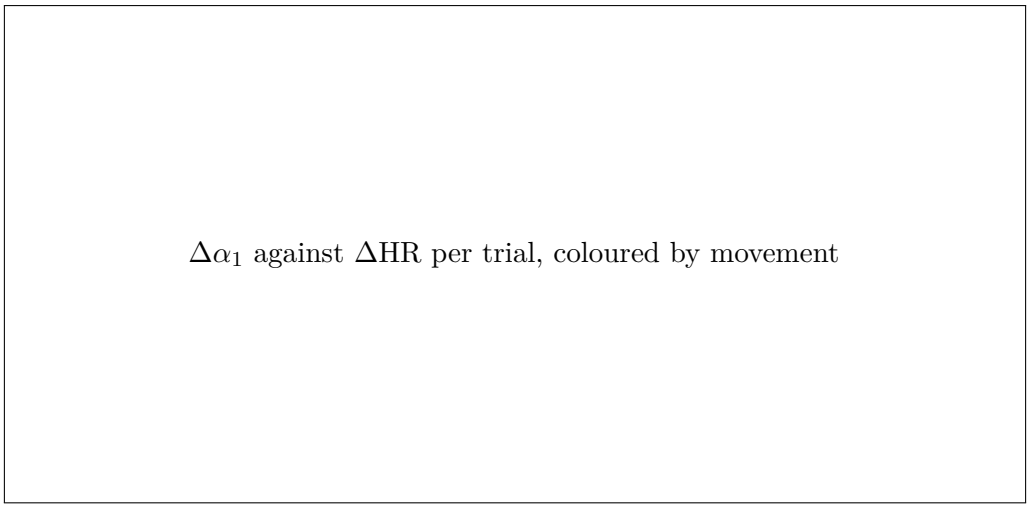


Figure 3: [todo: Figure 3]

6 Discussion

The present study was conducted to test whether skilled object manipulation leaves an acute trace in the fractal organisation of the heartbeat. Specifically, it aimed to (1) test whether two minutes of stick manipulation shift α_1 relative to a standing baseline, (2) test whether such a shift exceeds what the rise in heart rate predicts, and (3) explore whether it depends on expertise. [todo: main finding per aim, each with its key number, in three to four sentences]

The discussion is organised around three questions: (1) in which direction α_1 moves during stick manipulation; (2) whether this shift is specific to skill or explained by physical load; and (3) what this implies for the stick as a research tool. The interpretation depends on the outcome, and Table 6 sets out in advance how each pattern would be read.

Table 6: Pre-specified interpretation of possible outcomes.

Outcome	Reading	Next step it motivates
α_1 falls towards 0.75–0.5, explained by HR	Ordinary intensity effect; the stick behaves like light exercise	Match conditions on HR before testing skill effects
α_1 falls beyond what HR predicts	Task-specific change in autonomic organisation, consistent with engaged regulation or co-activation [34]	Relate to flow ratings; compare isolations and spins at matched HR
α_1 stays near 1.0	Fractal organisation preserved under a demanding motor task	Compare with a non-skilled movement control
α_1 rises towards 1.5	Shift towards regularity, e.g. breathing locked to the movement rhythm	Record breathing; test respiratory entrainment directly
Expertise or hand differences	Skill demand modulates autonomic organisation	Longitudinal practice; movement quantification

6.1 Direction of the Shift

[todo: interpret the H1 result against the landmarks of Table 1]

If α_1 falls during manipulation, the most economical reading is the one established in exercise

research. As physical demand rises, the many regulatory influences on the heart are progressively dominated by a single drive, and short-term correlations weaken [20, 21]. A fall towards 0.75 would place stick manipulation in the range of light to moderate exercise, which would be informative in itself, because the movement looks physically undemanding. A fall towards 0.5 at only modestly raised heart rate would be harder to explain by load and would point to a change in the organisation of regulation.

If α_1 rises, the complexity framework offers a different reading. A shift towards 1.5 indicates that a slow, regular component has come to dominate the series [19]. In the present task the most likely source of such a component is breathing. If breathing locks to the rhythm of the movement, as locomotor–respiratory coupling would predict [2, 24], respiratory sinus arrhythmia imposes a regular oscillation on the heartbeat at the movement frequency or one of its subharmonics. A rise in α_1 would then be a cardiac trace of coupling between movement and breathing, which the present design cannot confirm without a respiratory signal but which can be tested directly in future work.

If α_1 stays near its resting value, the result is still informative. It would show that fractal organisation holds during a task that demands continuous visuomotor control. Endurance exercise at a comparable heart rate lowers α_1, so this result would argue against the view that any motor engagement reduces correlation structure.

6.2 Skill or Load?

[todo: interpret H2: does the isolation–spin difference survive the HR adjustment]

The heart-rate adjustment is the crux of the design. Two minutes of stick manipulation raise heart rate, and α_1 is known to fall with heart rate, so a raw difference between baseline and movement is expected on physiological grounds alone. The question is whether isolations and spins, which differ in their demands on control and rhythm, differ in α_1 at matched heart rate. Isolations, which load visual prediction and fine control, are the more likely candidate for an effect beyond load; spins, which load rhythm and timing, are the more likely candidate for respiratory entrainment. [todo: relate the observed pattern to this contrast]

Two caveats apply. Heart rate is an imperfect proxy for physical load in arm tasks. Small muscle groups raise heart rate less per unit of effort than whole-body exercise, and the static holding in isolations may raise blood pressure more than heart rate. And the covariate adjustment assumes that the relation between heart rate and α_1 is the same in both movements, which can be checked but not guaranteed in a small sample.

6.3 Expertise

[todo: interpret H3]

Because most participants were experienced, the main results describe how the heart responds to the movements as practised performers do them. The expertise analysis asks whether this response changes with the amount of practice. The hypothesis follows from the stages of skill learning [18]. If novices perform the movements under explicit control and experts largely automatically, the regulatory demand of the same movement differs between them. A smaller departure from baseline α_1 in experts at matched heart rate would be consistent with this account and with the transient

hypofrontality view of skilled performance [15]. The literature on rhythmic coupling adds a second possibility. If experts have learned to coordinate breathing with the movement, their α_1 could shift further towards regularity, as stable coupling imposes a regular respiratory rhythm. These two accounts predict different directions, and the observed pattern discriminates between them [todo: which one]. While a cross-sectional comparison can show whether such a difference exists, a longitudinal study is needed to show that practice causes it.

6.4 The Stick as a Research Tool

[todo: interpret the Bland–Altman result and data quality]

A secondary aim was to establish whether a low-cost chain of consumer hardware and open software can measure α_1 during object manipulation. Data quality during movement, the agreement between real-time and offline estimates, and the practicality of two-minute trials all bear on this. If agreement is poor, as the pilot recordings suggested it might be, future studies need to compute α_1 offline from raw RR intervals with documented settings, as recommended for exercise research [25].

6.5 Implications: Towards a Somatic Interface

The study was motivated in part by a broader programme that uses signals from the body to map out mental states and builds interfaces for somatic journaling, in which bodily measures and reported experience are recorded together. For such an interface to be useful, a bodily signal has to change reliably with something a person does or experiences, and ideally it has to be possible to move it on purpose. [todo: relate to the results: does α_1 change reliably with the movement, and does expertise change how it moves]

Two lines of theory make this programme scientifically tractable. Interoceptive accounts treat the brain's representation of bodily state as a core ingredient of feeling and selfhood [12]. Predictive-processing versions describe emotion and the embodied self as the brain's best guess about the causes of signals from inside the body [42]. On this view, cardiac dynamics are one of the inputs from which the experienced bodily state is built, and a practice that reshapes them could reshape that state.

A more phenomenological line comes from the work of Steven Lehar. In his Gestalt Bubble model, conscious experience is an explicit, volumetric model of the world and the body within it, constructed by the brain [31, 32]. The body image at the centre of this model links perception to action. Motor planning takes the form of field-like forces in this space, which pull the body towards some postures and actions and away from others. Lehar's model concerns spatial and visual experience and makes no predictions about heart rate. It is relevant here as a framework in which bodily state, movement and experience share one structured representational space, which is the kind of map a somatic journaling interface tries to build from measured signals. A skilled movement practice is a natural test case for such a map, because it changes both what the body does and how the practitioner reports feeling. [confirm: keep this paragraph short in the final version; examiners may prefer the interoception framing]

6.6 Limitations and Future Research

For the present study, several limitations should be noted when interpreting the findings. Trials lasted two minutes, which yields one estimate of α_1 per trial and no information about how α_1 develops within a movement bout; longer bouts are not feasible for isolations without repeated breaks. Upper-body movement introduces artifacts, and the chest strap's error for α_1 grows during activity and in the uncorrelated range [9, 40]. Breathing was not recorded, so respiratory changes during movement, a plausible driver of any shift, cannot be separated from other mechanisms. The analysis relies on a monofractal short-term index; multifractal and long-range structure were not assessed [19]. The sample is small and consists mainly of experienced practitioners, many recruited through the seks.design community and known to the experimenter. Their results describe practised performers and may not generalise to people new to the practice, and their expectations about the practice could influence how they perform and report it. With only a few novices, the contrast between groups is descriptive. The standing baseline matches posture and grip, but holding the stick still involves a light isometric hold that differs from both rest and movement. Finally, the study contains no non-skilled movement control matched for effort, so the contrast between skill and load rests on the statistical adjustment for heart rate.

Each limitation points to a next step. A respiratory belt or the H10's accelerometer-derived breathing signal would allow coupling between movement, breathing and heart rate to be quantified directly, using the frequency-locking and phase-coupling measures of the coupling literature [23]. A metronome condition would test whether external rhythm stabilises the coordination, as it does in cycling [24]. A non-skilled rhythmic arm movement matched for heart rate would provide the control that the present design approximates statistically. Finally, a longitudinal study, as originally proposed for this thesis, would test whether daily practice changes resting α_1 and the response to the movements. The health relevance of fractal dynamics ultimately depends on this question [19, 33]. [todo: expand once results are in; close the limitations with a judgement on whether they affect the conclusions qualitatively or only quantitatively]

7 Conclusion

[todo: write after results, about half a page]

This thesis asked whether two minutes of rhythmic stick manipulation shift the fractal organisation of the heartbeat, as indexed by DFA α_1, and whether any shift is specific to skilled manipulation or explained by physical load. [todo: main finding and direction]. [todo: specificity after heart-rate adjustment]. [todo: expertise]. Beyond the specific result, the study shows how a portable recording chain built from a chest strap, a phone and open software can measure the organisation of cardiac regulation during skilled object manipulation, and it sets out the controls (heart rate as a covariate, breathing, a matched non-skilled movement) that future work on skill, flow and autonomic complexity will need.

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8 Appendix

8.1 Abbreviations

BLE	Bluetooth Low Energy
bpm	beats per minute
DFA	detrended fluctuation analysis
α_1	short-term scaling exponent of DFA (box sizes 4–16 beats)
α_2	long-term scaling exponent of DFA (box sizes 16–64 beats)
ECG	electrocardiography
fBM	fractional Brownian motion
fGN	fractional Gaussian noise
HR	heart rate
HRV	heart rate variability
ICC	intraclass correlation coefficient
LoA	limits of agreement
LRC	locomotor–respiratory coupling
pNN50	percentage of successive RR differences larger than 50 ms
RMSSD	root mean square of successive differences
RR	interval between successive R waves (beat-to-beat interval)
SDNN	standard deviation of normal-to-normal intervals
VT1	first ventilatory threshold

8.2 Trial File Format

Each trial was saved as a JSON file with the fields listed below, alongside a line-delimited log of every raw message received from the streaming application.

`session_id`	condition, participant and start time
`condition`	condition label, e.g. `baseline`, `isol_l`, `spin_r`
`participant_id`	pseudonymous participant code
`recorded_at`	ISO timestamp of trial start
`target_duration_s`	set trial duration in seconds
`sample_count`	number of RR intervals received
`samples`	list of RR intervals with arrival timestamps
`computed_stream`	real-time metrics reported by the streaming application

8.3 Pre-session Questionnaire

The questionnaire takes about two minutes and is completed on a phone or laptop before the strap is fitted [confirm: final wording and form].

Demographics

1. Age (years)
2. Sex
3. Height (cm) and weight (kg)
4. Which hand do you write with? (left / right / both)

Health and today

5. Do you have a heart, lung or neurological condition? (yes / no)
6. Do you take medication that affects heart rate, such as beta-blockers? (yes / no)
7. Did you have coffee, tea or energy drinks in the last 2 hours? (yes / no)
8. Did you drink alcohol in the last 24 hours? (yes / no)
9. Did you do strenuous exercise in the last 24 hours? (yes / no)
10. How many hours did you sleep last night?
11. Do you smoke or vape? (no / occasionally / daily)
12. How many hours of physical exercise do you do in a typical week?

Experience

13. How long have you practised with the isolation stick? (never / under 6 months / 6–24 months / 2–5 years / over 5 years)
14. How long have you practised other flow-arts props (poi, staff, juggling, contact, hoop)? (same options)
15. In a typical week, how many hours do you practise any flow-arts prop?
16. How would you rate your isolations? (1 = cannot do them, 10 = expert)
17. How would you rate your spins? (1 = cannot do them, 10 = expert)
18. Can you keep isolations going for 2 minutes without dropping the stick? (yes / no / not sure)
19. Can you keep spins going for 2 minutes without dropping the stick? (yes / no / not sure)

8.4 Supplementary Tables

[todo: per-participant artifact rates; per-participant α_1 per condition; full model outputs]